

Identity, Social Networks and Online Communication

GUY MERCHANT

Sheffield Hallam University, United Kingdom

ABSTRACT Arguments about whether or not the Internet is creating new people or simply helping us to see ourselves in new ways are threaded through the literature on digital culture. People make new technology and exploit it for their own purposes and so it is reasonable to suggest that any changes in our social identities are wider in their reach than the digital media through which they may be expressed. By taking a perspective that is informed by the social theory of Giddens, this article explores the relationship between identity performance and social network theory, and in so doing, aims to set an agenda for future research that enables us to capture how identities are played out across social networks in both online and offline interactions.

Introduction

I went from being one person with single name to existing as a number of identities created by me but not always recognisable as me, even by myself. (Thomas, 2004, p. 9)

In the burgeoning literature on digital culture, the area of identity and online communication has attracted considerable attention. Whether work has aimed to theorise an aspect of new communications and literacy, or whether it has attempted to shed light on new practices through empirical study, the fact remains that there is something about changing patterns and practices of interaction through new media that raises important questions about social identity. The study of adult e-communication repeatedly shows that much online interaction is interwoven with identity performance (Turkle, 1995; Markham, 1998; Sunden, 2003; Thomas, 2004). A similar preoccupation has been observed in children's digital interactions (Merchant, 2004). There are a variety of possible explanations for this interest. The most persuasive revolve around one of two considerations: one related to the affordances of the technology itself, and the other based on an account of the wider social conditions in which new technology is embedded.

The first of these explanations derives from an acknowledgement of the impact of the recent and rapid increase in alternatives to face-to-face communication. Although the facility to communicate with those who are not present, or who are geographically remote, is arguably as old as writing systems themselves, new technology undoubtedly provides us with a range of tools which enable us to interact in different ways within more diverse and dispersed networks than previously imaginable. From this perspective, new tools for communication provide a context for new kinds of identity performance, or as some commentators argue, have helped to create a new kind of person (Thomas, 2004).

A second and alternative explanation for this growing interest in social identity and new media derives from a broader view of the contemporary social context. Wide-reaching changes in the economic, political and social order, which have had both global and local impact, have produced the necessity and the desire to create and maintain new kinds of social networks (Giddens, 1991). The rise of a new capitalism (Gee, 2004) with a global reach has given rise to a system in which it is less likely that goods are produced and consumed locally, and more likely that production is coordinated across locations and that goods are marketed to consumer types, rather

Critically examine how anchored and transient identities are negotiated in online environments. In your answer please integrate social network theory and discuss how online platforms affect the performance visibility and stability of individual identity.

than geographical locations. This sort of arrangement requires the development of particular communicative tools, but more pertinently leads to the emergence of new social identities; identities that are more accurately defined by lifestyle, media consumption, and affinity spaces than by the more traditional markers of race, class, gender and place (Kress & Van Leeuwen, 2001).

Whichever explanation we find the most persuasive, it seems an inescapable fact that the landscape of communication has changed, and indeed continues to change, and that fact in turn raises new possibilities for constructing and performing social identity. In what follows I explore some of the dominant themes in online identity performance and develop a theoretical account which draws on previously published work (Merchant, 2004, 2005; Davies & Merchant, *in press*). On the basis of this, I draw attention to the significance of social context and show how social network theory can be used to extend and enrich this account. An initial examination of the discourse of identity threat is used to highlight the ways in which the idea of identity in the age of the Internet has captured our attention. This leads on to an overview of theoretical understandings about identity and then to the specific concepts of anchored and transient identities. This is then related to the area of social network theory and an examination of its implications for the study of identity and digital culture.

The Discourse of Identity Threat

New possibilities for identity performance through new media have fired the imaginations of both fictional narrative and speculative work on new technology, but they have also fuelled our anxieties (Bauman, 2004) and sense of future shock (Toffler, 1971). Resistance to change, often coupled with a latent tendency to mistrust technology, has led to the emergence of a particular kind of discourse, a discourse inflected by moral panic. Scare stories tend to focus on the Internet, usually constructed by the popular media as a 'place' inhabited by weird and scary people, in which weird and scary things take place.^[1] Although such stories undoubtedly have their basis in fact, they are of interest here because they illustrate the importance we attach to identity (in this case constructed in terms of threat) in computer-based communication. In order to illustrate this, consider five themes of these scare stories:

- Your virtual property is never secure; it can be stolen or maliciously corrupted by viruses.
- Your personal details are easy to locate, so easy that Internet criminals can steal and use your identity (your money).
- You are constantly under surveillance: where you go, what you do and what you say is always tracked.
- Your personal safety is at risk; children and young people, in particular, are at risk from sexual predators.
- You shouldn't trust who you meet; people aren't who (or even where) they say they are.

What underpins each of these themes is the idea that engaging in Internet-based communication can actually pose a threat to one's identity, or to put it another way, going online involves putting yourself on the line. This threat persists despite the fact that nothing about sitting in front of a screen actually constitutes a direct physical danger, in contrast, for example, to the way that crossing a busy street or making one's way through a neighbourhood with a reputation for street violence does. This, of course, is not to minimise the possible dangers, but merely to be more precise about the nature of the discourse around identity threat.

Allied to the discourse of threat, but at least in some ways distinct from it, is the idea that Internet-based environments are unstable and that the everyday sense of trust that lies behind face-to-face communication (Grice, 1975) is no longer a reliable assumption. When Turkle (1995) first explored the possibilities of online identity experimentation she encouraged the growth of the idea that cyberspace allowed, or even promoted, new ways of performing identity. In retrospect, the notion that adopting an identity that might cross gender or racial boundaries was somehow new ignored centuries of carnival, role-play, cross-dressing and other forms of identity shift. Despite the moral panic around identity shift, often formulated as 'never believe that who you are communicating with is who they say are', it now seems more plausible to suggest that in some genres, such as email, people are more likely to use everyday identities than in others (such as

MMPOLGs).[2] Hence identity shift is more common in some environments than others, just as in everyday life.

The discourses of identity threat and identity shift are, however, united by a common concern. The lynchpin of this concern is the uncertainty that comes with the absence of physical co-presence. Of course this is not new – most written genres are predicated on this – but the immediacy and high level of interactivity of much screen-based communication pulls it closer to conversation, where co-presence is the norm (Crystal, 2001). Shared physical space and the richness of information that is communicated in face-to-face interaction goes far beyond the linguistic unit. Face-to-face communication is truly multimodal, as Argyle's work carefully illustrates (Argyle, 1983, 1990). In comparison, screen-based interaction is a 'lean medium' (Herring, 2004), a medium which is not only usually stripped of the paralinguistic features of gesture and eye contact, but one in which the respondent is noticeably absent. The sense of who we are communicating with is, then, drastically reduced. I suggest that the effect is that we are likely to work much harder to get a sense of who we are communicating with and, in turn, to work harder to produce ourselves in this new communicative medium. This could be at least one reason why identity captures our attention and why it has become a salient theme in the study of digital culture.

Performing Identity

For the playwright Pirandello, all identity is seen as an artificial construct that depends for its existence on the faith and love of others. Pirandello's character the Father in *Six Characters in Search of an Author* says:

we have this illusion of being one person for all, of having a personality that is unique in all our acts. But it isn't true. (Pirandello, [1921] 1995)

Throughout his work, Pirandello suggests that each one of us has many different possibilities of being and that, although we imagine some sort of unity, we are actually different in each different social situation. This, of course, is a highly contentious position to adopt, partly because it challenges essentialist discourses of the social self, but when we revisit what has been written about identity performance in cyberspace it begins to make sense. Certainly, in looking at the complex debates around virtuality and authenticity one thing becomes clear: that a theory of identity, and a robust account of its relationship with online and offline social relationships, is long overdue.

Gee (2003, 2004) develops a theory of identity, based on the experience of videogaming, which begins to illustrate some of the subtleties involved in working in disembodied role-play environments. His theory outlines three aspects of identity that come into play in the context of gaming. He suggests that a game-player creates a 'virtual identity', a character with certain attributes and particular ways of acting, which interact with the player's 'real-world identity'. A third aspect comes into play with the 'projective identity'. This refers to the projected identity that is developed through playing the character, constituted by a dynamic interaction between the first two identities and the possibilities and constraints of the game design (Gee, 2004, pp. 112-113). The strength of Gee's theory is the way in which it establishes a clear relationship between real-world and virtual identities. It is also worth emphasising that in referring to real-world identity, Gee is not assuming that there is a single essentialist identity; rather, he acknowledges the composite and dynamic nature of what he calls 'real-world identity'.

The sorts of identities that are performed in online communication are likely to vary considerably with the environment (email, discussion board, blog or online game) and the nature of the relationship (familiarity or affinity) to the other or others. Although choices are available, they are constrained by the affordances of a particular medium and the social conventions that emerge around that particular form of communication (Merchant, 2006). So outside of the game environment we would anticipate that most of the time, online communication would involve some enactment of real-world identity; or perhaps, more accurately, real-world identities.

To illustrate this, Figure 1 shows a digital photograph taken by nine-year-old Nazar. He is involved in a link project and has gathered together a collection of objects to represent himself and his interests. He will use this as an image file attached to an email when introducing himself to his partner in the link school. His collection of significant items includes a spelling trophy, a calculator,

a travel brochure (written in Urdu) and a Koranic neck pendant. The following comment accompanies the image file: 'my most valuable thing is my chain to show my religion'.

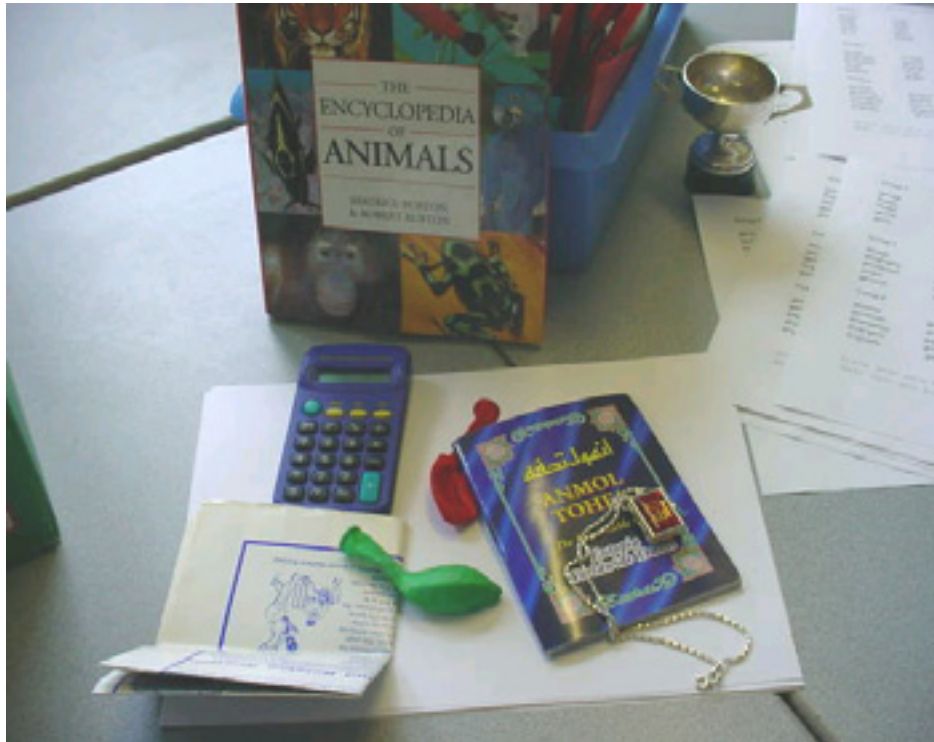


Figure 1: '... my chain to show my religion'.

Out of the choices available, Nazar has decided to make an overt identity statement, highlighting a significant part of his real-world identity. Although the photograph includes some items of personal significance (such as the balloons and the calculator), one is struck by the way that the chain has been laid across the brochure, allowing for associations to be made between religion and ethnicity. The accompanying message, of course, points to this, making explicit reference to its religious significance, something which would be difficult to establish simply by studying the image on its own. In a subsequent message, Nazar adds to this depiction of his real-world identities:

MY HOBBY IS FOOTBALL AND BIKE RIDING. MY BEST FRIEND IS SUBHAAN. I WAS BORN IN PAKISTAN. I LIKE PAKISTAN MORE THEN ENGLAND.

From this simple communicative act, which constitutes a first step in online communication, the complexities of self-presentation are highlighted. Nazar, in signalling his identity draws on different facets of his lifeworld. The spelling lists, trophy and perhaps the calculator (in the photograph) seem to capture aspects of his school identity, whereas the message that foregrounds his interest in football and bike riding aligns him with peer group culture. This is placed alongside his ethnic and religious identity. The complexity of this particular act of identity performance shows how different layers of everyday action and activity play out against the background of wider markers and patterns of social organisation.

Identity Markers: transient and anchored identity

Social theorists like Giddens (1991) and Bauman (2004) convincingly argue that identity in the late modern world is contingent, multiple and malleable. It is suggested that the individual is active in producing and performing an ongoing narrative of the self. As Giddens explains:

The existential question of self identity is bound up with the fragile nature of the biography which the individual 'supplies' about herself. A person's identity is not to be found in behaviour,

nor – important though this is – in the reactions of others, but in the capacity to keep a particular narrative going. The individual's biography, if she is to maintain regular interaction with others in the day-to-day world, cannot be wholly fictive. It must continually integrate events which occur in the external world, and sort them into the ongoing 'story' about the self. (Giddens, 1991, p. 54)

This idea of keeping 'a particular narrative going', or building a dynamic story of oneself in our social worlds, is also found in the work of Holland et al (1998), who provide an account of identity which is also characterized by fluidity and improvisation. In theorising identity and agency at work in a range of social and cultural contexts, Holland and her colleagues:

take identity to be a central means by which selves, and the sets of actions they organize, form and re-form over personal lifetimes and in the histories of collectives. (Holland et al, 1998, p. 270)

So here, the idea that identity is *produced* through action and performance becomes important. A plural narrative begins to develop, and our perception of an actual or imagined audience prompts us to think about what we wish to show (Grosz, 1994). Identity performance, then, inevitably involves a sense of audience: an audience to whom one is presenting a particular narrative (or narratives) of the self.

In an auto-ethnographic study of academic blogging (Davies & Merchant, in press) this interaction between the development of plural narratives and the sense of audience was traced through reflective work on blog publishing. We concluded that in publishing online, our blogs became texts for self-presentation which we hoped would 'be accepted as appropriate and plausible performances' (Hine, 2000, p. 122). This extract from the metablog we used in our study captures this idea:

I have an ongoing story. But I think we have several ongoing stories. I also think that if we bear in mind a particular audience, we change our story to suit them and thus change our notion of who we are according to our audience. (Blogtrax, 2005)

Whilst it is relatively easy to accept that we draw on different facets of our multiple identities in different communicative settings (both on- and offline), the actual choices we make are more complex and certainly more interesting. How we account for the choices Nazar made above, or the gendered patterns of publishing and commenting that emerge from the blogging study, is problematic.

In earlier work (Merchant, 2005), I used the terms 'anchored' and 'transient identity' in an attempt to distinguish between positions which are profoundly influenced by a long history of socio-cultural practices (such as gender or religion) and those which are more easily made, remade and unmade (such as fandom). Anchored and transient identities were not conceived of as simple binary divisions, but poles on a continuum: a continuum from which instances of identity performance are drawn. I also suggested that interactions, contexts and events are likely to make certain aspects of identity more or less salient at any given time and in any particular social interactions. Examples of anchored identities are gender, position in family, religion, age, social class and geographical location. They relate to aspects of our lives over which we have little control and are least likely to change. On the other hand, transient identities change over time, being influenced by maturation, changing cultural conditions and peer group affiliations. These identities are defined in relation to media narratives, ideologies, popular culture, iconic objects, social activities and networks.

Distinguishing between these different aspects of identity does seem to be useful in providing a more robust account of texts produced in online communication in which real-world identities are mobilised. Anchored and transient identities overlap and interact (as the texts by Nazar illustrate). The following extract from a discussion thread on a school discussion board provides another illustration of this sort of interplay. The children are between seven and eight years of age.

Emily: I GOT LODES OF XBOX GAMES WHAT SORT OF GAMES DID YOU GET?

Ravi: WHICH FIFA DID YOU GET

Thomas: I got a psp and fifa soccer

Sasha: I got 1 bratz doll, an xbox with 3 games and a bratz tourbus

A discussion thread on Christmas gifts provides the overall frame for these posts. This is a child-initiated topic, but of course it does assume the shared cultural experience of gift-giving at Christmas, which may have automatically excluded some from the discussion. This aspect of the discussion seems to highlight the importance of social context (which is addressed below). But even within this context there are some interesting nuances. The participants buy into a shared discourse which is organised around branded products. The discussants are united around the theme of games machines (PSP and Xbox); Gee (2003) might describe this as an affinity space, in the sense that discussion participants organise themselves around interest or affinity. What is interesting, however, is the way in which Sasha subverts this thread by introducing Bratz dolls. Whilst still relating to the theme of branded products and making specific reference to the xBox, she introduces a product which is a strong gender marker, and in so doing evokes a wider social category (an anchored identity).

If anchored and transient identities help us to understand and categorise aspects of online interaction (Merchant, 2005) they are perhaps less effective in describing the wider contextual fields in which these identities are played out. If identity is indeed 'performed', then as we have seen, the ideas of audience, readership and community are indispensable.

Identity and Social Networks

Earlier on I referred to a study of academic blogging (Davies & Merchant, in press) which emphasised how bloggers create multiple narratives of the self when publishing online. This study also underlined the importance of a sense of audience in refining those varied narrative acts of identity performance. In writing online, how we conceive of and respond to audience, and how we imagine our readership, is clearly of central importance. This point is emphasised by Hine when she argues that the production of a web page 'is made meaningful primarily through the imagining of an audience and the seeking of recognition from that audience' (Hine, 2000, p. 136).

The suggestion could even be generalised to all forms of communication that are not face-to-face, including all those interactions or communicative contexts in which the imagining of an audience becomes crucially important. For much computer-based communication the imagined audience relates quite closely to actual social networks. Of course this overlap is more the case in some environments (such as email and instant messaging) than others (such as web pages and MMPOLOGs). It seems, then, that a more informed view of social networks may actually enrich our view of identity performance. Here the work of Wellman (Wellman, 2002; Wellman & Hogan, 2004; Wellman et al, 2005) is particularly useful.

Wellman and his colleagues, through a number of empirical studies, have developed a theory of social networks that shows how trends in the use of new technology are embedded in the wider, changing landscape of social interaction. Wellman et al (2005) use a tripartite model to chart the shift from traditional close-knit communities to 'glocalised' networks (which are both global and local) and on to what they call 'networked individualism'. Close-knit communities (or groups) are collocated and most communication is face-to-face, whereas glocalised networks are based on place-to-place communication. Wellman goes on to suggest that, in the case of networked individuals, the person rather than the place becomes the locus of connectivity. He uses the mobile phone to exemplify this.

With the internet and the mobile phone, messages come to people, not the other way around. Individuals are connected by their phones, but their phone is not tied to a place and its environment (such as family or office). (Wellman et al, 2005, p. 1)

In an earlier article, Wellman (2002) suggests that, whilst his tripartite theoretical model signals directional changes in patterns of social organisation, it is quite possible that many people inhabit a social world which is actually a mixture of groups and networks. We know through various iterations of the idea of a digital divide (for example, Facer et al, 2003) and from studies of new technology in different contexts (for example, Ito, 2005) that technological innovation is not homogenous in its uptake or effects. This, combined with the relatively slow adoption of wireless connectivity in some sectors of society and in some countries, could help to illustrate how the movement from groups to networks is uneven.

In order to give a closer examination of Wellman's social network theory, it is useful to look at the phenomenon of blogging (see Merchant, 2006 for an overview). Now, although there is no reason why a blog could not be used to communicate within a traditional close-knit community, one would imagine that its prime communicative purpose would be mostly redundant in that news, views, interests, ideas and so on would normally be shared in face-to-face interactions. However, in glocalized networks, blogs can serve the purpose of providing communicative links, and a degree of interactivity between local and dispersed individuals who have common interests, constitute a community of practice (Wenger, 1998) or operate in an affinity space (Gee, 2003). In this way, blogging software supports the emergence of glocalized networks. Potentially at least, blogs can be updated or commented on from any location, and so in this sense they can also be a tool for the sorts of person-to-person communication that lies at the heart of Wellman's (2002) definition of networked individualism.

A personal blog (see Figure 2 for an example) enables the user to communicate to and receive responses from a loosely defined social network that could include locally and geographically remote friends or colleagues, as well as others with similar interests who may not be known to the author.

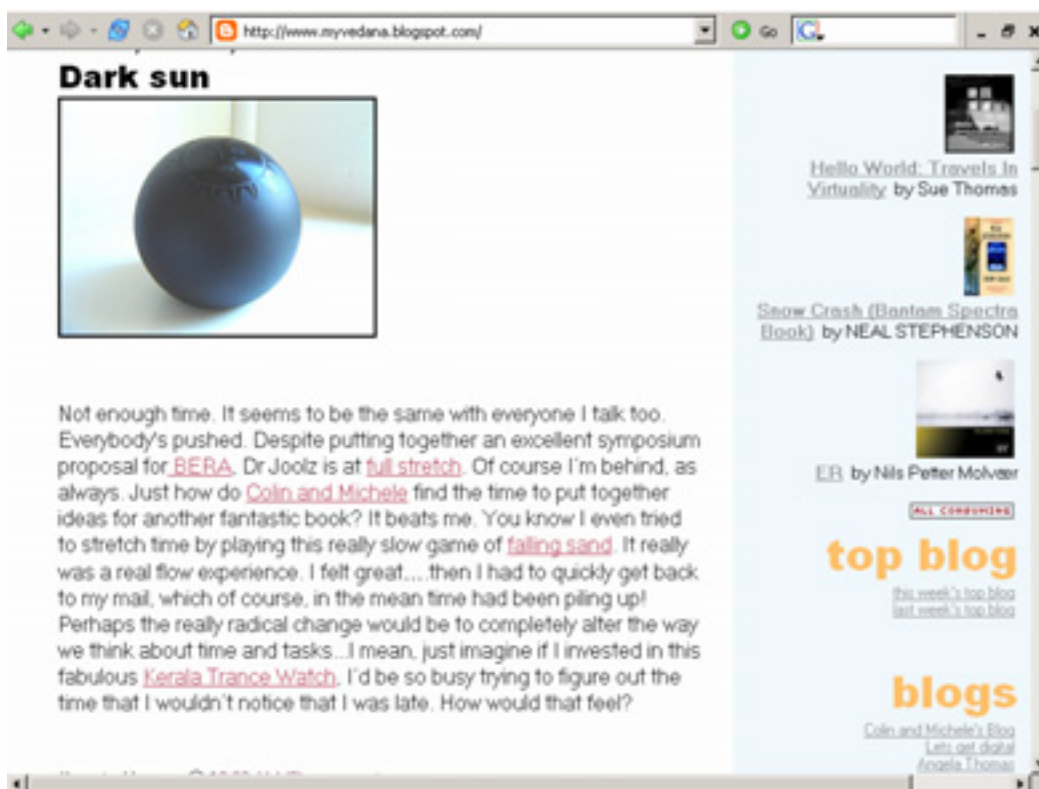


Figure 2. Personal blog.

At the same time, though, as we have seen, the blog provides a space for authoring social identities. To be precise, the blog format allows for identity to be produced in a variety of different ways. Blogger profiles, and template choice or modification, as well as the style and content of postings all provide these social affordances. In addition to this, many bloggers use the sidebar to provide additional information which helps to locate them in specific social networks. Blogrolls and favourite web-links are quite explicit ways of showing one's affiliations, whereas add-ons such as 'allconsuming', detailing what the author is currently consuming (re-skinned in the example under 'Interests')[3], and links to photosharing sites (such as Flickr photostreams) all provide opportunities to showcase anchored and transient identities.[4] Although most of this is consciously controlled by the blog owner, at least at a superficial level, I am confident that a richer sense of identity may well be communicated at a deeper level, in ways that lie beneath the conscious

control of the author. Although I consciously decide on which links I show and what themes I address, my position as a middle-class white male, my liberal socialist predispositions and my age group will no doubt become clear to the reader despite my attempts to sound younger, more radical and so on.

Looking at blogging as one particular genre of online communication lays the foundation for a more in-depth study of the relationship between identity and social networks. As Wellman observes, the move to networked individualism raises important questions about the emergence of new social identities. Wellman poses two questions that are pertinent to our discussion here:

- Will networked individualism deconstruct holistic individual identities?
- To what extent does the Internet reduce the importance of traditional social organising criteria such as gender, social class, ethnicity, language, life-cycle stage, and physical location? (Wellman, 2002, p. 16)

An acknowledgement of the reality of multiple real-world identities, which informed the earlier discussion of identity performance, seems to call into question the existence of the 'holistic individual identities' that Wellman refers to. On the other hand, the framework of anchored and transient identities suggests that new forms of communication allow for a repertoire of performance which may in turn draw on a range of narratives of the self, some based around well-established social organising criteria and others around more transient preoccupations.

Conclusion

The online environments that new technology provides offer new challenges and possibilities for self-presentation and impression formation in human communication. Whether or not online environments actually create new people or simply help us to see ourselves in new ways may be a debate that we need to leave behind in favour of a more sophisticated analysis of digital interaction. In this article, I have drawn attention to what I believe are important considerations in the study of identity online. Emphasis has been given to identity performance and the ways in which it mirrors multiple and shifting perceptions of audience. Writing online, in whatever form it takes, provides us with the opportunity to 'author the self' (Holland et al, 1998), to sustain a narrative of identity (Giddens, 1991), and even to explore a number of different stories of the self, but these identities are forged through our connection with others.

By exploring the shift in social organisation from location-based communities to glocalised networks (Wellman, 2002), I suggest that we develop a richer view of the varied contexts and audiences for identity performance. There is now a need to catalogue the detail of how identities are played out across social networks in both on- and offline interactions. Further studies are needed to explore three interlinked themes. First, we need a deeper understanding of the ways in which online interaction and offline engagement work together in the development and maintenance of specific social networks. Secondly, we need to understand how individuals perform identity across social networks. Since networked individualism is based on the idea that social agents are selective in the interests and affiliations they display, it would be interesting to see how particular narratives of identity develop over time. Finally, we need to look at the ways in which specific online environments support or enhance social networking and how they provide opportunities for dispersed individuals to construct and negotiate identities.

Notes

[1] For a fuller account of what worries people about the Internet, see Thomas (2004, pp. 146-150).

[2] MMPOLGs are massively multiplayer online games, such as EverQuest.

[3] Allconsuming can be accessed at <http://www.allconsuming.net>.

[4] Flickr can be accessed at <http://www.flickr.com>.

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GUY MERCHANT is Principal Lecturer at Sheffield Hallam University, where he coordinates the work of the Language and Literacy Research Group. His research within the field of new literacies focuses on children and adolescents and their engagement with new media. He is Research

Convenor for the United Kingdom Literacy Association. Recent publications address young children's uses of onscreen writing and how this can be incorporated into the school curriculum, and an auto-ethnographic study of academic blogging (with Julia Davies). *Correspondence:* Guy Merchant, Sheffield Hallam University, Faculty of Development and Society, Collegiate Campus, Sheffield S10 2BP, United Kingdom (g.h.merchant@shu.ac.uk).